heightening security at airports, railway stations, bus terminals and ferry stands, besides strict vigilance on the waters of the Indian Ocean—this had already led to arrests of many LTTE cadres. All this, he knew, could eventually lead to him too. He drew Pottu Amman's attention to the cash rewards of ten lakh and five lakh rupees for information leading to his and Shubha's arrests, respectively. He was asking his boss to get him out of the country. Sivarasan sounded upset over the lack of response to his earlier messages for a boat.[5]

Pottu Amman's response suggested that the LTTE's political group leader, Gundu 'Trichy' Santhan, would help him out. But Santhan had gone underground, so Pottu Amman was waiting for communication from him. Sivarasan insisted on faster action. To that Pottu Amman said he would organize a meeting for them in the house of an LTTE sympathizer who was an engineer and lived in Eldams Road, Madras. Pottu Amman ended the conversation by telling Sivarasan to shut down the current communication set-up as it was becoming risky to use it. Amid the numerous dead ends the SIT was meeting, this seemed to be a solid opportunity to catch the mastermind. The SIT swung into action. Karan and Datta flew down from Delhi and camped at Malligai.

Round-the-clock surveillance was mounted on the Eldams Road area where the LTTE sympathizer was supposed to live. It was a posh locality with very few pedestrians—a quiet area, which made it easy for the sleuths to monitor it undercover. It was the biggest operation to nab One-Eyed Jack since the failed Pulicat lake operation. Many extra precautions were also taken to avoid any slip-up.

Verma was keeping watch from inside a van parked about a hundred yards away from the building. Ragothaman was watching from the window of an adjoining building. Kanth and Raju monitored the operation from inside a makeshift surveillance van. Others, including the NSG commandos and the Madras Police special task force, all in plain clothes, kept watch on the apartment from rooftops of neighbouring buildings, from the streets, from inside a parked truck and a black-and-yellow taxi. Some others kept an eye on the area from autorickshaws plying around Eldams Road.